

*Describe the world you come from; for example, your family, school, community, city, or town. How has that world shaped your dreams and aspirations?** 250

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Transferring from a small public school deep in the San Fernando Valley to a K-8th school overlooking LA for highly gifted students was like switching worlds. A personal MacBook awaited me inside my new Apple-sponsored 4th-grade classroom. We had typing tests instead of spelling quizzes. Two students behind me celebrated their 75 wpm. Scoring a zero myself, I aspired to become comfortable with this foreign 13-inch piece of hardware that was now mine.

Opening up my laptop at home, I was mesmerized by the ability to color-code desktop folders and “inspect element” on webpages. I started with Lego Robotics and Scratch, but the programming classes I began taking in middle school inspired me to push myself. I branched out to new languages: XCode and Unity at Hackathons, HTML, CSS, and Javascript, which I learned on the job as a Product Design Intern at an AI company, GumGum, and implemented at my junior year hackathon. We created a website, winning third place, that integrated Spotify’s Web API--the perfect combination of my love for music and programming.

Suddenly adapting to a world of technology has helped me remember there is always more room to innovate and learn. With my interests in music, sustainability, and the natural sciences, combined with computer science, I hope to work on things like these: using AI to recognize musical patterns and compose songs, combining programming and robotics to improve the recycling process by detecting contaminated waste, and using genetic programming to see how gRNA aids CRISPR-Cas9 technology.

325

Transferring from a small public school deep in the San Fernando Valley to a K-8th school overlooking LA for highly gifted students was like switching worlds. A personal MacBook awaited me inside my new Apple-sponsored 4th-grade classroom. We had typing tests instead of spelling quizzes. I struggled for an entire minute trying to correctly type “the” as my seat partner covered my view of the keyboard. As two students behind me celebrated their 75 wpm, I aspired to become comfortable with this foreign 13-inch piece of hardware that was now mine.

Opening up my laptop at home, I was instantly mesmerized by the ability to color-code folders on my desktop and “inspect element” on web pages. I started with Lego Robotics and basic HTML, but the programming classes I began taking in middle school made me want to push myself to obtain new skillsets. I branched out to new languages and software: XCode and Unity at Hackathons, HTML, CSS, and Javascript, which I learned on the job as a Product Design Intern at an AI company, GumGum, and implemented at my junior year hackathon. We created a website, winning third place, that integrated Spotify’s Web API--the perfect combination of my love for music and programming.

The experience of coming from a less “tech-savvy” school and all of a sudden being immersed in a world of technology has helped me remember that there is always more to learn and always room to innovate. I hope to continue building my computer science skillset, learn to collaborate on programming projects with others, and find more ways to connect my passions.

With my interests in music, sustainability, and the natural sciences, like biology and chemistry, I hope to learn things like: using AI to recognize musical patterns and compose songs, combining programming and robotics to improve recycling plant sensors that separate contaminated waste from recyclable waste, and using genetic programming to see how guide RNA aids CRISPR Cas9 technology.

Making the world a better place: At MIT, we bring people together to better the lives of others. MIT students work to improve their communities in different ways, from tackling the world's

biggest challenges to being a good friend. Describe one way in which you have contributed to your community, whether in your family, the classroom, your neighborhood, etc.*250 words

Poll Working

v3 -248 - own

In 2020, I decided to become a poll worker, to aid and learn more about the democratic process, and fill in for the thousands of senior citizen poll staffers at higher risk of contracting COVID-19. On November 3rd, we were met with protestors, city council campaigners, and first-time voters, all eager to cast a ballot.

I helped voters navigate the digital voting technology, translated screens to Spanish, tried my best to communicate with non-English speakers, and, for some, was even asked to press their selections for them.

Nov 3rd, my site supervisor gestured to me and guided an elderly woman to the station I was working at, instructing me to help her load their ballots and make their selections. She told me about her desperate, courageous immigration from Ukraine that informed her gratitude towards American society and culture, her love for the freedom to choose, her ability to vote. She broke down, holding my arm, shedding tears over the political disconnect between her and her daughter.

Although I disagreed with her views, it was not my job to change someone's mind. I was there to help them fulfill their cherished right to vote as themselves, informed however they chose to be, whether through past experience, research, or even a gut feeling. At the end of the day, it didn't matter if I helped someone vote for Kanye West, President Biden, or Former President Trump, as long as their voice was heard and their right to choose their representatives was protected.

v2 -248

In 2020, I decided to become a poll worker, to aid and learn more about the democratic process, and fill in for the thousands of senior citizen poll staffers at higher risk of contracting COVID-19. On November 3rd, we were met with protestors, city council campaigners, and first-time voters, all eager to cast a ballot.

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v1 - 318

In 2020, I decided to become a poll worker, to aid and learn more about the democratic process, familiarize myself with how to best inform my future votes, and fill in for the thousands of senior citizen poll staffers at higher risk of contracting COVID-19. It wasn't until election day that I became aware of just how impactful voting was to members of my community. On November 3rd, we were met with protestors, city council campaigners, and first-time voters, all eager to cast a ballot with varying degrees of political and emotional intensity.

I helped voters navigate the digital voting technology, translated screens to Spanish, and tried my best to communicate with non-English speakers, and for some, although going against my own political opinion, was asked to press their selections for them. I remember one encounter, in particular. My site supervisor gestured to me and guided an elderly couple to the station I was working at, instructing me to help them load their ballots and make their selections.

Making small talk with the lady I was helping, I learned of her desperate and courageous immigration from Ukraine that informed her graciousness of American society and culture, her love for the freedom to choose, her ability to vote. She broke down, shedding tears over the political disconnect between her and her daughter and her opinions on America she viewed the candidate she opposed would create.

Although I disagreed with her views, it was not my job to change someone's mind. I was there to help them fulfill their cherished right to vote as themselves, informed however they chose to be, whether through past experience, research, or even a gut feeling. At the end of the day, it didn't matter if I helped someone vote for Kanye West, President Biden, or Former President Trump, as long as their voice was heard and their right to choose their representatives was protected.

v0

The 2020 election was the first presidential election I followed with a decent understanding of American democracy and politics, and although I entered political conversations in my home, school community, and friend circles in a time of intense polarization, I felt like I was somewhat fulfilling the, possibly self-imposed, duty to be an informed citizen in our democratic society. My inability to vote made me feel disconnected from the conversations I was having up until election day.

I decided to become a poll worker to aid and learn more about the democratic process, familiarize myself with how to best inform my future votes, and fill in for the thousands of senior citizen poll staffers at higher risk of contracting COVID-19. My first day working the polls, I learned how to register voters, cast ballots, and read up on California's candidates and propositions. It wasn't until election day that I became aware of just how impactful voting was to members of my community.

November 3rd we were met with protestors, city council campaigners, and first-time voters, all eager to cast a ballot with varying degrees of political and emotional intensity. I helped voters navigate the digital voting technology, translated screens to Spanish, and tried my best to communicate with non-English speakers, and for some, although going against my own political opinion, was asked to press their selections for them.

One encounter, in particular, helped me internalize the impact I was making. My site supervisor gestured to me and guided an elderly couple to the station I was working at, instructing me to help them load their ballots and make their selections. Making small talk with the lady I was helping, I learned of her desperate and courageous immigration from Ukraine that informed her graciousness of American society and culture, her love for the freedom to choose, her ability to vote. She broke down, shedding tears over the political disconnect between her and her daughter and her opinions on America she viewed the candidate she opposed would create. Although I disagreed with her views and had informed myself on some of the topics she touched upon, I came to the realization that it was not my job to change someone's mind or persuade them of something they didn't believe, I was to help them fulfill their cherished right to vote as themselves, informed however they chose to be, whether through past experience, research, or even a gut feeling. At the end of the day, it didn't matter if I helped someone vote for Kanye West, President Biden, or Former President Trump, as long as their voice was heard and their right to choose their representatives was protected.

Bored of Boredom?

Challenges and opportunities: Tell us about a significant challenge you've faced or something that didn't go according to plan that you feel comfortable sharing. How did you manage the situation?*
250 words